WEST BENGAL/ TMC

BATTLE LINES DRAWN IN TMC

By Romita Datta



HIS OWN MAN Abhishek Banerjee at a TMC rally in South Dinajpur district

PTI

A fortnight after the 'generational feud' in the Trinamool Congress erupted on social media, party chairperson Mamata Banerjee finally broke her silence at the hastily organised organisational polls on February 2. After being re-elected to the post (obviously without contest), the first thing she did was to assert her supremacy. "A leader does not fall from the heavens. He/she becomes one through work," she said amid deafening silence. The gibe, many say, was directed at nephew and party No. 2 Abhishek, seated next to her, and the young brigade, who had been going ga-ga on social media over his 'leadership qualities', especially the way he enforced Covid protocols in his Lok Sabha constituency, Diamond Harbour, when the Gangasagar Mela was on.

On January 8, Abhishek had come out and made comments against the mela, which Mamata, also the West Bengal chief minister, had been hyping as a "people's event" despite the surge in Omicron numbers in the state. Abhishek made a pointed jibe, saying such mass celebrations of religious festivals when Covid was raging had to stop to "save the state and society". As if to prove a point, he also rolled out a massive Covid testing drive in his constituency and ensured strict protocols for Mela visitors. The party's Lok Sabha chief whip and senior leader Kalyan Banerjee had questioned Abhishek's audacity in making such public comments then, which set off the sniping war between supporters of the old guard and those of Abhishek.

A GROWING RIFT

The situation has been simmering for some time, so much so a joke doing the rounds is are you Trinamool Kalighat or Trinamool Camac Street? (The reference is to Mamata's home in Kalighat and Abhishek's office in Camac Street.) In matters of candidate selection, the two have seldom been on the same page the last year, be it for the 2021 assembly election or the recent Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) polls. The differences came out in public when Mamata rejected poll strategist Abhishek and Prashant Kishor (PK)'s candidate list of the civic polls. PK had fashioned last year's famous assembly poll victory and is now part of the TMC think-tank. Sources say, for the first time in Trinamool's history, there were heated arguments over the choice of candidates between Mamata and her nephew.

The same issues flared up on February 4 when the party's IT cell uploaded a list of candidates for the polls in 108 municipalities on the TMC website. Soon, the leadership was compelled to publicly dismiss it as a fake list. "This list did not have the signature of senior leaders Partha Chatterjee and Subrata Bakshi, who were assigned by Didi to prepare it," reveals a party MLA on condition of anonymity. "We suspect that PK's team, which looks after the party's IT cell, was behind it. This was PK's wish list, which the leadership turned down." PK and Abhishek are said to be in agreement about a revamp of the